

TURKISH DELIGHT

Jeanne Antoinette Poisson, better known as Madame de Pompadour (1721–64), was the powerful mistress of Louis XV of France from 1745 to her death. When she commissioned artist Charles André van Loo to paint her as a Turkish Sultana, Pompadour started a craze for *portrait à la turque*. Exotic oriental culture was already widely popular in France, and *Turquerie*, as the craze was known, permeated all aspects of French art and fashion.

Both women in this picture wear a loosely wrapped turban (Madame de Pompadour's is decorated with her signature rose), a flowing, long-sleeved shift worn over a full skirt with a natural waistline and, on top, a long jacket in rich colours. Pompadour wears an ornate belt with full, baggy silk trousers. She kept several styles of these garments in her wardrobe and enjoyed wearing them in private. Pearls were particularly favoured by women at this time, and, here, Pompadour has them entwined in her hair, hanging from her ears, and around her neck. Her hair is dressed in a style she helped to popularize, drawn back close to the head in a small bun, from which a few curls fall onto the neck or over the shoulder to decorate the nape.

“

The first piece of my dress is a pair of drawers very full that reach to my shoes. Over this hangs my smock of a fine white silk gauze, edged with embroidery...The smock has wide sleeves...the shape and colour of the bosom is very well distinguished through it...

LADY MARY WORTLEY MONTAGU, *TURKISH EMBASSY LETTER*, 1717

”

MADAME DE POMPADOUR ▷

This portrait of Madame de Pompadour, *A sultana served coffee by a slave*, was by one of her favourite painters, Charles André van Loo. Painted in the mid-18th century, it shows Pompadour in exotic Turkish attire.

